Quas Primas

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ENCYCLICAL OF PIUS XI

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THE FEAST OF OUR LORD JESUS CHRIST, KING

(Quas Primas)

In the first encyclical which We addressed to all the bishops of the Catholic world on the occasion of Our elevation to the Supreme Pontificate, in which letter We outlined the principal causes of the calamities with ' which We saw mankind oppressed and harassed, We remember having stated then quite definitely that evil has spread throughout the world because the greater part of mankind banished Jesus Christ and His holy law from their lives, their families, and from public affairs, and that there never would arise a sure hope of lasting peace among the peoples of the world as long as individuals and nations continued to deny or refused to acknowledge the rule of Christ, Our Savior. We gave warning at that time that it is necessary for all men to seek "'the peace of Christ in the Kingdom of Christ." We announced, too, that We would do every- thing possible to attain this, the purpose of Our

pontificate. We used the phrase "the Kingdom of

Christ," because it seemed to Us that the establishment of peace could not be achieved except by the restora- tion of the Kingdom of Our Lord. Meanwhile, the be- ginning of a movement of the peoples of the earth to- ward Christ and His Church, from Whom alone salva- tion can come, gave Us renewed hopes of better times. It was a movement in which We perceived that many who had hitherto despised the Kingdom of Christ and who had practically exiled themselves from their Father's house were prepared, and were even anxious, to tread again the paths of obedience.

Should not all that has happened during this Holy Year, a year worthy of perpetual remembrance, in- crease the honor and glory of the Divine Founder of the Church, Who is, at the same time, Our Supreme King and Lord? The Vatican Missionary Exhibition has influenced most deeply the hearts and minds of men. It has made known the lasting work of the Church whose great purpose is to extend the Kingdom of her Spouse into every continent, even to the most remote islands of the seas. It has also shown how great is the number of countries which have been won over to Catholicism by the sweat and blood of courageous and self-sacrificing missionaries. In spite of this noble work many vast regions remain to be conquered for the be- nign and saving rule of Our King.

Those great multitudes who, during the Year of Jubilee, came from every part of the globe to the Holy City, led by their bishops and priests, their hearts

purified by the grace of the sacraments, what more noble thing could they have done than proclaim them- selves, both before the Tombs of the Apostles and before Us, faithful subjects of Christ, now and for- ever? This Kingdom of Christ appeared almost suf- fused with a new light when We raised to the honor of the altar six confessors and virgins whose heroic virtues had been amply proven beforehand to all mankind. What joy, what comfort We experienced when, amid the splendors of the Vatican Basilica, having promul- gated the solemn decrees of their canonization, an im- mense multitude of people spontaneously raising their voices in a hymn of thanksgiving cried out: 'Thou, O Christ, art the King of Glory." Thus, while men and nations, alienated from God because of mutual hatred and internal discords, are rushing headlong to- ward ruin and destruction, the Church of God con- tinues to feed mankind with the food of the spiritual

life. She still creates and fashions generations of saints _

for Jesus Christ. He, on His part, does not cease to bring to the joys of the Kingdom of Heaven those who have proven themselves faithful and obedient subjects of His earthly Kingdom.

Added to this was the celebration of the Sixteenth Centenary of the Council of Nicea which occurred during this Jubilee Year. We desired that this Cen- tenary should be worthily commemorated, and We Ourselves commemorated it in the Vatican Basilica. This We did all the more willingly because the Holy

Synod of Nicza had defined the dogma of the con- substantiality of the Son and the Father and had, at the same time, inserted in the Creed the formula "of whose reign there will be no end." In these words it proclaimed the royal dignity of Christ.

This Holy Year, therefore, having made known in more ways than one the Kingdom of Christ, it seemed - well to Us to do all that Our Apostolic office implies by closing it with the institution of a special feast for the liturgy in honor of Our Lord Jesus Christ, King. We did this after many cardinals, bishops, and the faithful, both singly and collectively, had importuned Us to do so.

All these events have given Us so much joy that We are constrained to speak. We ask you, Venerable Brothers, to adapt what We here write about the cult of Jesus Christ, Our King to the intelligence of your people and to explain its full meaning to them so that much spiritual fruit may be derived from the annual celebration of this great feast.

Since ancient times it has been customary to bestow

in a metaphorical sense upon Christ the title of King because of His lordship over all created things. As King, He reigns in the minds of men, not only because of the keenness of His own mind or the vastness of His knowledge, but because He is the Truth. It is, therefore, necessary that all men seek and receive in full obedience the truth from Him. Likewise, He reigns

\ over the wills of men, either for the reason that in Him

reside perfect command over and complete eto of the human will to the behests of the Divine Will, or because by His holy inspirations He influences our, free wills in such an efficacious way that we are led to)

desire only the noblest things. Finally, He reigns as

King of our hearts because of that love of His "which surpasses all knowledge" (Ephesians iii, 19) and of the supreme attraction for us of His divine meekness and kindliness. No man, in fact, ever was so much loved as Jesus Christ, or ever will be.

In order to enter more intimately into the merits of this question We assert that it is necessary to vindicate for the Christ-Man both the name and power of a King in the full and literal meaning of that term. As a matter of fact, it is of Him as man that it has been said that He received "power, honor, and king- dom" (Daniel vii, 13, 14) from the Father. The rea- son for this is that since He is the Word of God, of

the selfsame substance as the Father}|He must have

in common with the Father all that pertains to the divine nature, and, by consequence, He possesses full and absolute sway over all created things.

Do we not often read in the Holy Scriptures that Christ is King? He is called "the Prince who shall come out of Jacob" (Numbers xxiv, 9), "who has been named by His Father King of Sion, the Holy Mountain,

who shall receive the Gentiles for his inheritance, and the utmost parts of the earth for his possession." (Psalms ii, 8) In the Psalm of the Beloved, in which

under the image of a rich and powerful king is pre-figured the future King of Israel, we read the words: "Thy throne, O God, is forever and ever: the sceptre of thy Kingdom is a sceptre of uprightness." (Psalms xliv, 7) Besides many other passages We may cite one which clearly portrays the character of Christ | when it predicts that His Kingdom will extend from sea to sea and will be marked by the reign of justice and of peace. "In his days shall justice spring up and abundance of peace . . . he shall rule from sea to sea, and from the river unto the ends of the earth." (Psalms Ixxi, 7, 8) To the above testimonies must be added the startling predictions of the prophets, and in a special manner that most notable prophecy of Isaias: "For a CHILD IS BORN to us, and a son is given to us, and the government is upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called, Wonderful, Counsellor, God the Mighty, the Father of the world to come, the Prince of Peace. His empire shall be multiplied, and there shall be no end of peace: he shall sit upon the throne of David, and upon his kingdom; to establish it and strengthen it with judgment and with justice, from henceforth and for ever: the zeal of the Lord of hosts will perform this." (Isaias ix, 6, 7)

The other prophets are in complete agreement with Isaias, and especially Jeremias when he foretold that a "Just Seed" would be born of the House of David, and that this Son of David 'a King, shall reign and shall be wise; and shall execute judgment and justice

in the earth." (Jeremias xxiii, 5) Daniel, too, foretells the founding of a kingdom by the Lord of Heaven who "will set up a kingdom that shall never be de- stroyed . . . it shall stand forever." (Daniel ii, 44) "T behold therefore," continues the prophet, "in the vision of the night, and lo, one like the son of man came with the clouds of heaven, and he came even to the Ancient of days: and they presented him before him. And he gave him power, and glory, and a king- dom: and all peoples, tribes and tongues shall serve him: his power is an everlasting power that shall not be taken away: and his kingdom that shall not be destroyed." (Daniel vii, 13, 14)

The writers of our Holy Gospels recognize that in Jesus Christ was fulfilled the prediction of Zacharias concerning the "Meek King" when He, "the Just One and the Savior, rode upon an ass and upon a colt, the foal of an ass" (Zacharias ix, 9) into Jerusalem, amid the acclamations of the multitude! This doctrine — of Christ the King which We have taken from the very words of the Old Testament is found in the New, wherein it is confirmed in a most remarkable manner. In the New Testament is contained the announcement of the Archangel informing the Virgin Mary that she shall conceive and bear a Son "and the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of David, his father, and he shall reign in the House of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there shall be no end." (Luke i, 32, 33) Christ Himself bears testimony in His own words to

the existence of His Kingdom. Thus, both in His last discourse to the multitude when He spoke of the re-wards and punishment which shall be meted out for all eternity to the just and the unjust, when He replied to the Roman Consul who publicly asked Him if He were a King (Matt. xxv, 31, 40), or when, after His resurrection He bestowed upon the Apostles the office of teaching and baptizing, Christ took every oppor-tunity to call Himself a King, and to publicly and solemnly affirm His Kingship (John xviii, 37) for to Him had been confided all power both in heaven and on earth. (Matt. xxviii, 18) Could He possibly have meant anything else by these words than that His regal power was absolute and that His Kingdom ex- tended over all? It should not surprise us, therefore, if He Whom John called the "prince of the kings of the earth" (Apoc. i, 5) when He appeared to the Apostle, as narrated in the vision of the Apocalypse, wore "on His garment and on

His thigh written: King of Kings, and Lord of Lords." (Apoc. xix, 16) Since the Eternal Father has made Christ His heir in all things (Hebrews i, 2) it is necessary that He should rule until the end of time, that is "until he hath put all his enemies under his feet." (I Cor. xv, 25)

As a result of this doctrine which We take from the Holy Scriptures, the Church, the Kingdom of Christ on earth, which by divine command is spread among all men and nations, proclaimed Him, her Founder, in the annual cycle of the liturgy, Sovereign Lord and

King of Kings. In affectionate veneration for Christ she multiplies the titles of honor which she bestows upon Him. These same titles are expressed in manifold beautiful ways, as for example, in the ancient antiphonaries and sacramentaries, in the holy office, and in the daily Sacrifice of the Immaculate Host at Mass. It is by this constant praise of, Christ the King that is shown, too, the wonderful harmony which exists be- tween our own Rite and that of the Eastern Churches, so much so that the axiom "legem credendi lex statuit supplicandi" takes on thereby a most profound mean- ing.

St. Cyril of Alexandria, writing on this subject, points out the basis for the royal dignity and power of Christ when he says: "He obtained dominion over every creature not by force nor because of any merely external reason, but because of His very, essence and nature." (On Luke x.) What St. Cyril affirms is that the royalty of Christ is founded solely on that ad-— mirable union in Him of two natures which we call the Hypostatic Union. From this truth it follows that Jesus Christ must be adored not only as God by angels and men, but that they must be subject to and obey Him as well because He is Man: it is by reason of the fact of the Hypostatic Union, and that alone, that Christ — has power over all creatures.

What thought could be more beautiful and more inspiring than that Christ rules over us, not only by right of birth but also by right of conquest, brought

about by His Redemption of mankind? God desired forgetful man to recall at what great price we were bought by our Savior. "Knowing that you were not redeemed with corruptible things as gold or silver, from your vain conversation of the tradition of your fathers: but with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb unspotted and undefiled." (I Peter i, 18, 19) We, therefore, no longer belong to ourselves alone, for Christ has bought us at a "great price." (I Cor. vi, 20) Our bodies too are "members of Christ." (I Cor. vi, 15)

May We at this point define the nature and importance of this supremacy of Christ. It consists of a threefold power, of which if even one element were missing, it could be said to contain no longer the idea of a true and real supremacy. The texts of the Sacred Scriptures which treat of the universal empire of Our Redeemer superabundantly prove this truth. It is a dogma of faith that Jesus Christ has been given to men as their Redeemer in Whom they must believe, and as a lawmaker Whom they must obey. (Council of Trent, Session VI, Can. 21) The holy Gospels not only tell us that Christ promulgated laws; they also present Him in the very act of making laws. Under different circumstances and in somewhat different words the Divine Master affirms that whosoever will keep His commandments gives proof thereby of loving Him and will remain in His love. (John xiv, 15; xv, 10) Christ Himself affirmed in the presence of the Jews,

who had accused Him of having violated the Sabbath by curing the paralytic, that the Father had bestowed upon Him judicial power. "For neither doth the Father judge any man, but hath given all judgment to the Son." (John v, 22) By this we must understand that He possessed also the right of rewarding and punishing men even during their lives since this inheres in the power of judging. Executive power must equally be attributed to Christ, since it, is necessary for all to obey His commands. No one can escape them without suffering the punishments He has decreed.

That this His Kingdom is spiritual and that to it belong for the most part spiritual things, the passages of the Holy Bible referred to above show, and Jesus Christ Himself confirmed by His deeds. On various occasions when the Jews and even the Apostles them- selves believed, though falsely, that the Messias would free the chosen people and re-establish the Kingdom of Israel, He sought to dispel this vain idea and false hope from their minds. When He was about to be proclaimed King by the multitude that admiringly crowded about Him, He declined the title and honor, and fleeing from them, hid Himself in the desert. Finally, He announced before the Roman Consul that His Kingdom "was not of this world."

In the Gospels this Kingdom of Christ is presented in the following manner. Men must prepare themselves to enter therein by means of penance and they cannot enter except through faith and the sacrament of Bap-

tism, which, though an external rite, is a sign of and produces sanctifying grace. This Kingdom is opposed only to the kingdom of Satan and the powers of darkness. It demands from its subjects not only that their souls be detached from riches and worldly things that they govern their lives justly, that they hunger and thirst after justice, but that they renounce themselves and take up their cross. Who is there who cannot per- ceive this royal dignity in the spiritual character of Christ the Redeemer founding the Church by His blood, and of Christ the Priest offering Himself forever as a sacrifice of propitiation for the sins of men? Moreover, since Christ has received from the Father absolute dominion over all created things so that all are subject to His will, they err grievously who would take from the Christ-Man power over temporal things. On earth He abstained completely from exercising that power and despised material possessions and the care of worldly

things. He has permitted to others and, still permits, rightful possession of them, but commands that the possessors must serve Him, not their pos- sessions. The beautiful words "He does not take from us mortal things Who bestows upon us heavenly king- doms"' are well adapted to show this. (Hymn Crudelis Herodes in office of Feast of Epiphany.) The domin- ion of the Redeemer embraces, therefore, all men, as was said in the words of Our Predecessor of lasting memory, Leo XIII, which We here gladly make Our own: "The Empire of Christ extends not only over

Catholic peoples and over those who, reborn in the font of Baptism, belong by right to the Church, even though error has driven them far from her and dis- sension has separated them from the bond of love; it embraces even those who do not enjoy the privilege of the Christian Faith, so that all mankind must be said to be under the dominion of Jesus Christ." (Encyclical Annum Sacrum, 25 May, 1899)

Nor is any distinction to be made between individ- uals, the home, or civil society, for men are no less un- der the dominion of Christ when united in social groups than as single individuals. He alone is the source of both individual and public welfare. "Neither is there salvation in any other. For there is no other name under heaven given to men, whereby we must be saved." (Acts iv, 12) He alone is the Author of pros- perity and true happiness, individual and _ societal. "The duties of the holy city and the duties of men do not differ; for the city is no other than''a concourse of men." (St. Augustine, Letter to Macedonius, C. I11) If the heads of nations wish the safety of their govern- ments and the growth and progress of their country, they must not refuse to give, together with their people, public testimony of reverence and obedience to the empire of Christ. What We said at the beginning of Our Pontificate about the breakdown of the principle of authority and of respect for government may fit- tingly be repeated here. "They have driven God and Jesus Christ," We then lamented, 'out of their laws

and governments. They have made authority appear to be something derived not from God but from man . . consequently its foundations are tottering. If the First Cause be forgotten, there is no reason why some should command and others obey. From this error arise wide- spread disturbances in society which can be said to rest no longer upon its natural foundations." (Encycli- — cal Ubi Arcano)

If men, both in private and publicly, will but recog- nize the sovereign power of Christ, the signal benefits of true liberty, of calm order, of harmony, and of peace will descend upon the whole human race. Just as the royal rights of Our Lord render the human authority of princes and heads of states sacred to a certain de- gree, so too they ennoble the duties imposed by obedi- ence on the citizen. Impressing upon wives and serv- ants the necessity of beholding Christ in their husbands and masters, St. Paul clearly warns that they should not obey them as men but because they recognize them as heirs of Christ. For no other reason would it be befitting for men redeemed by Christ to obey other men. "You are bought with a price; be not made the bondslaves of men." (I Cor. vii, 23) If princes and legitimate rulers will only be convinced that they rule not so much in their own right but by a mandate from and in place of the Divine King, it is easy to understand what holy and wise use they will make of their power, and with what zeal for the common good and the welfare of their subjects they will be inspired both in the mak-

ing and in the enforcing of laws. If this should happen, every reason for sedition would be removed and order and tranquillity would flourish and wax strong. When citizens see that their rulers and the heads of states are merely men like themselves, or are, for some rea- son, unworthy or culpable, they will continue, in spite of these facts, to obey their commands because they recognize in them the image of the authority of Christ, the God-Man.

As for the effect of all this upon concord and peace, manifestly the vaster the Kingdom of Christ and the more widely it embraces mankind, so much the more will men become conscious of the bond of brotherhood which unites them one with another. As the con- sciousness of brotherhood banishes conflicts, so too it softens bitter feelings and turns them into feelings of love. If the Kingdom of Christ, which de jure em- braces all men, should in fact embrace all, would we then despair of that peace which the King of Peace brought to earth, that King Who came "to reconcile all things, Who did not come to be served but to serve others," and Who, though the "Lord of all," made Himself an example of humility and established hu- mility and charity as His chief Law? "My yoke," He said, "is sweet and my burden light." Oh, what happi- ness might we not enjoy if individuals, families, and states would only allow themselves to be ruled by Christ! When all willingly accept the Empire of Christ and obey Him, when every tongue proclaims

that "Our Lord Jesus Christ is in the glory of the Father," then, indeed, to use the words of Our Pre- decessor, Leo XIII, when He addressed twenty-five years ago all the bishops of the Catholic world, "would many wounds be healed, the law would regain the prestige it once enjoyed, the blessings of peace would return, and swords and weapons would fall to the ground." (Encyclical Annum Sacrum, 25 May, 1899)

In order that these results which We desire for hu- man society may be more abundant and lasting, it is necessary that the royal dignity of Our Lord be recog- nized and accepted as widely as possible. To this end it seems to Us that nothing else would help so effectively as the institution of a special feast dedicated to Christ our King. The annual celebration of the sacred mys- teries is more effective in informing people about the

Faith and in bringing to them the joys of the spiritual life than the solemn pronouncements of the teaching Church. Documents are often read only by a few learned men; feasts move and teach all the faithful. The former speak but once; the latter every year and forever. The former bring a saving touch to the intel- lect; the latter influence not only the mind but the heart and man's whole nature. Being composed of body - and soul, man needs to be aroused by external

'solemnities so that, through the variety and beauty of the sacred liturgy, he may receive the divine teachings in his soul and, then changing them into his own sub-

stance and blood, may use them to advance in the spiritual life.

From history we learn that the feasts of the Church during the passing of the centuries were introduced one after the other, according as the needs or well-being of Christian peoples seemed to demand, as, for example, when it was necessary to strengthen people in the face of a common danger, defend them from the poisonous errors of heresy or strongly encourage them to celebrate with greater piety some mystery of the Faith or some blessing of divine grace. Thus, in the first centuries of the Christian Era, when the faithful were bitterly persecuted, sacred rites were decreed to commemorate the martyrs, until, as St. Augustine writes, the solemn functions of the feast days of the martyrs became themselves exhortations to martyrdom. (Sermon XLVII, de Sanctis). The liturgical honors that later were bestowed on confessors, virgins, and widows served marvelously to arouse in the faithful that love of virtue which is also necessary in the days when the Church is at peace. Especially were feast days created to honor the Blessed Virgin so that the Christian people might not only venerate with greater piety the Mother of God, of all heavenly patrons the greatest, but also be impelled towards a stronger love for her whom Our Redeemer in his last testament left to mankind as our Heavenly Mother.

Among the many benefits gained from this public veneration of the Mother of God and of the saints, not

the least valuable is that through this cult the Church, in all ages, has succeeded in rooting out the plague of heresy and error. In this We must admire the designs of Providence who draws good from evil, for in spite of a weakening of both faith and piety from time to time and the spread of error, Catholic truth, supported by Divine Providence shone forth in new splendor in spite of all opposition, and men being awakened from their spiritual lethargy, have striven to achieve greater and holier objectives. As a matter of fact, the feasts that occur during the course of the liturgical year which have been instituted in our own times, had the selfsame origin and produced similar effects. Thus, when respect for and the worship of the Most Blessed Sacrament grew weak, the Feast of Corpus Christi was instituted, and was ordered to be celebrated in such manner that the solemn processions and the prayers recited over a period of eight days would recall people to their duty of venerating publicly Our Lord. When, because of the forbidding rigorism of Jansenism, the souls of men had grown weak and they had lost heart, the Feast of the Sacred Heart of Jesus was instituted so that their coldness might give way to love and they themselves might be reclaimed by the love of God and the promise of everlasting strength.

Now when We, therefore, command that Christ our King be venerated by Catholics throughout the world, We are providing for the special needs of our own day a very effective remedy against the plagues which

infest human society. The plague of the age is what is called secularism, with all its attendant errors and impious purposes. You know, Venerable Brothers, that such impiety does not spring up over night. For a long time it has been eating its way into the very vitals of society. As a matter of fact, the rule of Christ over mankind has been denied, the Church has been refused the right, which comes from the very law of Jesus Christ to teach all peoples, to make her own laws for the spiritual government of her subjects in order to bring them to eternal happiness. Little by little the Christian religion has been made the equal of other and false religions and has been lowered to their level. The Catholic religion has been made subject to the civil power and has been given over to the control of rulers and statesmen. This error went still further; an attempt was made to substitute a certain vague natural religion for the truth of the religion of Christ. There were not wanting governments which imagined they could do without God altogether and cover up their lack of religion by irreligion and disrespect for God Him- self. We have already written in sorrow in Our encyclical Ubi Arcano of the evil effects of this aban- donment of Christ on the part both of individuals and of nations. Today We again grieve over these things, over the seeds of discord sown everywhere, the re-

kindling of hatreds and rivalries between peoples which prevents the re-establishment of peace; We grieve over those unrestrained passions so often hidden un-

der the mask of promoting the public good and of love of country; the civil discords which arise from this source together with that blind unmeasured egotism so widely diffused and which, thinking only of each one's private good and welfare, measures all things by this false standard; over domestic peace grievously disturbed because of forgetfulness and wilful disregard of family duties; over the natural unity and stability of the family which have been broken; and, last of all, over society itself shaken to its foundations and plunging headlong to ruin.

In spite of these sorrows We are sustained by the holy hope that the Feast of Jesus Christ Our King, which will be celebrated hereafter every year, will at last lead back society to Our Blessed Savior, an end which all men

devoutly look forward to. To hasten this return to Christ by means of good works and organized social action is a duty incumbent on every Catholic, of many of whom it can be said truthfully that neither positions nor authority in civic life have been accorded them as befits those who carry before them the torch of truth. This condition perhaps is due to the apathy or the timidity of the good who abstain from strife and are apt to resist aggressions too weakly. Because of our weakness the enemies of the Church are embold- ened to greater and more fearless acts of audacity. But when the faithful clearly understand that they must fight with courage, always under the banner of Christ Our King, they will then study with the zeal

of apostles how best to lead rebellious and ignorant peoples back to God. At the same time they will themselves acquire strength to keep inviolate God's holy laws.

Certainly it appears to Us that an annual celebration of the Feast of Christ Our King will greatly assist all nations towards a condemnation, of and a reparation for those public apostasies which secularism, with so much harm to society, has given birth to. In fact, the more the dear name of Our Redeemer is passed over in shameful silence, be it at international meetings, be it in chancellaries, so much the more necessary is it to acclaim Him King and announce everywhere the rights of His royal dignity and power.

All can see that since the end of the last century the way was being prepared for the long desired institution of this new feast. No one can be ignorant of how this cult was spread and defended in books written in all the languages of the civilized world. The supremacy of the Kingdom of Christ was also recognized in the pious practice of those who dedicated, even consecrated, their families to the Sacred Heart of Jesus. Not only families but even whole nations and kingdoms were likewise consecrated. Due to the de- sire of Leo XIII, the human race, during the Holy Year of 1900, was solemnly consecrated to the Divine Heart. Neither should We pass over in silence the great number of Eucharistic Congresses, held especially in our own times, which marvelously assisted in solidi-

fying this royal power of Christ over mankind. These Congresses by calling upon each of the faithful in every diocese, state, and nation, as well as in the whole Catholic world, to venerate and adore Jesus Christ hidden under the veils of the Eucharist, and by means of public discourses and sermons, of public Exposi- tion of the Blessed Sacrament, and of wonderful processions, aimed to acknowledge and proclaim the Kingship of Christ, bestowed upon Him by heaven itself. Thus it can be said most truly that the Christian people, inspired by the grace of God, take from the silence and darkness of our sacred temples to carry in triumph through the public streets that selfsame Jesus, and thus aid to re-establish Him in His royal rights, Him Whom on His entrance into this world wicked men refused to recognize.

This Holy Year, now drawing to a close, appears to be a most timely occasion in which to effect the holy purpose of which We have been writing, since God manifestly blessed this Jubilee by raising the minds and hearts of the faithful to thoughts of those heavenly things which surpass all joy, by bringing them back to His grace, by confirming them in His holy way, by leading them to the attainment of spiritual perfection. Therefore, when We consider the innumerable petitions addressed to Us as well as all the events of the Holy Year itself, We judge that the day has finally arrived to announce that mankind should honor Christ the King at a special feast. In this year, as We said at

the beginning, Our Divine King, admirable in His saints, has been magnified in a truly marvelous way by the elevation of a new band of His faithful followers to the honors of the altar. During this same year, all people have been led to admire by means of the Mis- sionary Exhibition the triumphs of Christ gained by those saintly missionaries who, have extended His Kingdom on earth. Finally, We celebrated this year the Centenary of the Council of Nicza and thus com- memorated the definition of the dogma of the consub- stantiality of the Word made Flesh with the Father, a dogma upon which is founded the truth of the sov- ereign rule of the same Christ over all peoples. Therefore, in virtue of Our Apostolic authority, We institute the Feast of Our Lord Jesus Christ, King, and decree that it be celebrated everywhere and an- nually on the last Sunday of October, that,is, on the Sunday preceding the Feast of All Saints. Likewise We decree that on this same day, annually, there is to be renewed the consecration of mankind to the Sacred Heart of Jesus, an act of consecration which Our Predecessor of holy memory, Pius X, had previously commanded to be made every year. This year We wish the consecration to take place on the thirty-first of this month, on which occasion We Ourselves will celebrate solemn Pontifical Mass in honor of Christ the King. At that time the consecration to the Sacred Heart will be made in Our presence. Moreover, it seems to Us that it would be impossible in any more

fitting way to close and crown this Holy Year than to render the full meed of Our gratitude and of that of all Catholics to Christ, "Eternal King of the Ages," for the benefits conferred upon Us, the Church, and the whole Catholic world during the Holy Year just ended.

There is no need, Venerable Brothers, to explain at great length why We instituted the Feast of Christ, King, as a distinct feast despite the fact that the royal dignity of Christ appears to be amply recognized, at least by implication, in other feasts already decreed. It is enough, We believe, to tell you that although the so-called material object of all these feasts of Our Lord

is Christ, the formal objects are quite distinct from that of the new feast which expressly recognizes by name both the royalty and kingly power of Jesus. The reason, moreover, why We decreed that this feast should be celebrated on Sunday is because that day would give both to the clergy in the celebration of Mass and the recitation of the Divine Office, and to the laity, free from their daily occupations, an opportunity to render in the spirit of holy joy a special public act of obedience and devotion to Our Lord. Moreover, the last Sunday of October, when the close of the liturgical year is at hand, seemed to Us a most fitting time to order this celebration for the reason that it will so happen that the mysteries of the life of Jesus Christ commemorated during the course of the year will then terminate and be crowned, as it were, by this great

solemnity of Christ, King, thus exalting before all men the glory of Him Who triumphs in His saints and in His elect. Therefore, We desire that it should be your office, your special task, Venerable Brothers, to see to it that a course of sermons is preached every year on fixed days in every parish for the celebration of this feast so that the faithful, instructed fully in the nature, meaning, and importance of the feast, will be brought to lead lives altogether worthy of those who profess themselves loving and faithful subjects of the Divine King.

As We close this letter, Venerable Brothers, it is Our great pleasure to point out briefly what advantages for the Church, for society, and for each Christian We hope will flow from this public cult of Christ, King. In the first place, the very fact of our acknowledging publicly the royal honors which belong to,Our Lord, must of itself recall that the Church which was es- tablished by Him as a perfect society cannot but de- mand as her right, a right which she cannot renounce, full liberty and independence from the civil power. Moreover, the Church, in the exercise of her divine ministry of teaching, ruling, and guiding to eternal hap- piness all who belong to the Kingdom of Christ, mani- festly cannot depend on the will of others. The civil power, too, must allow to religious orders and institutes of both sexes the exercise of a like liberty since they, over and above being a help to the Church and her pastors, co-operate and assist greatly in the extension

and development of the Kingdom of Christ, either be- cause by their profession of the three religious vows they stand out against the threefold concupiscence of the world or because by their leading a life of great perfection they show forth daily to all men that holi- ness which the Divine Founder of the Church foretold would be one of the marks of the true Church.

The annual celebration of this feast will also be- come a means of recalling to the nations their duty of publicly worshiping Christ, that to render Him obedi- ence is not only the duty of private individuals but of rulers and governments as well. It will recall that at the final judgment the Christ Who has been ignored and despised, and even driven from public life and public affairs, will avenge all the injuries He has received. His royal dignity demands that society in general conform itself to the commandments of God and to the principles of the Christian life, first in the making of laws, then in the administration of jus- tice, and above all things in preparing the souls of our young people for the acceptance of sound doctrines and the leading of holy lives. Finally, who can com- pute the strength and holiness which the faithful them- selves will obtain by meditating on these things, if they do so with the object of modeling themselves on the true standards of the Christian life?

Now, because Christ Our Lord has been given all power in heaven and on earth, because all men re- deemed by His Precious Blood have been made His

subjects by a new and wondrous title of authority, because, lastly, this power of His extends to all man- kind, it does not follow that we lose any particle of our liberty by reason of the rule of Christ over us. It is necessary that Our Lord rule over the mind of man, who by this intellectual submission shall firmly and at all times assent to the revealed truth and doc- trines of Christ; that He rule over the will, which shall obey the divine laws and commands; that He rule over our hearts, which despising mere natural love shall love God above all things and be united to Him alone; that He rule over our bodies which as instru- ments, or as St. Paul says as "instruments of justice to God" (Romans vi, 13) shall promote the sanctity of the soul. If all these things are preached to the faith- ful they undoubtedly will be led the more easily to- ward perfection.

May the Lord grant, Venerable Brbihers, that the _ many who are not members of His Kingdom shall long for and some day accept the sweet yoke of Christ, and that all men who are, through the mercy of God, His subjects and His children, and their number indeed is great, shall bear this yoke not because they are forced to do so, but with pleasure, with love, and in the spirit of holiness. If our lives are thus made conform- able to the laws of this Divine Kingdom we shall gather abundant fruit thereby, and when called by Christ as good and faithful servants we too shall become sharers with Him in the Heavenly Kingdom of His everlast-

ing happiness and glory. Especially at this time of the year, as the anniversary of the birth of Our Lord Jesus Christ approaches, this great gift We desire for you, Venerable Brothers, as an expression of Our fatherly affection. We impart, too, from the depths of Our heart to you, Venerable Brothers, and to all your clergy and people, the Apostolic Blessing, a pledge of divine favors to come.

Given at Rome, at St. Peter's, on the eleventh day of December, of the Holy Year, 1925, the fourth of Our Pontificate.

PIUS XI.

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